

WHY I PRESCRIBE MARATHONS FOR MILERS

Within the last two years runners from sparsely populated New Zealand have broken no less than eight world records. Behind this astonishing success is the teaching of an athletic iconoclast, Arthur Lydiard, who sets for his pupils the world's hardest training regimen. He will, he says, gladly match it against any other method yet developed. In the article below Lydiard describes in detail his rigorous theories of success and suggests that even businessmen should run for their money.

by **ARTHUR LYDIARD**

My training system is not the super-human thing it's made out to be. In fact, I don't know how this business about pushing back pain barriers or driving beyond points of collapse ever got started. My system is as simple as it is effective: build up your endurance through marathon running.

In theory, I am trying to develop my runners until they are in a tireless state. In practice, this means I am trying to give

them sufficient stamina to maintain their natural speed over whatever distance they are running. Stamina is the key to the whole thing, because you can take speed for granted. No? Look here. Everybody thinks a four-minute mile is terrific, but it is only four one-minute quarter miles. Practically any athlete can run one one-minute quarter, but few have the stamina to run four of them in a row. How do you give them the necessary stamina? By making them run and run and run some more, until they don't even think in terms of

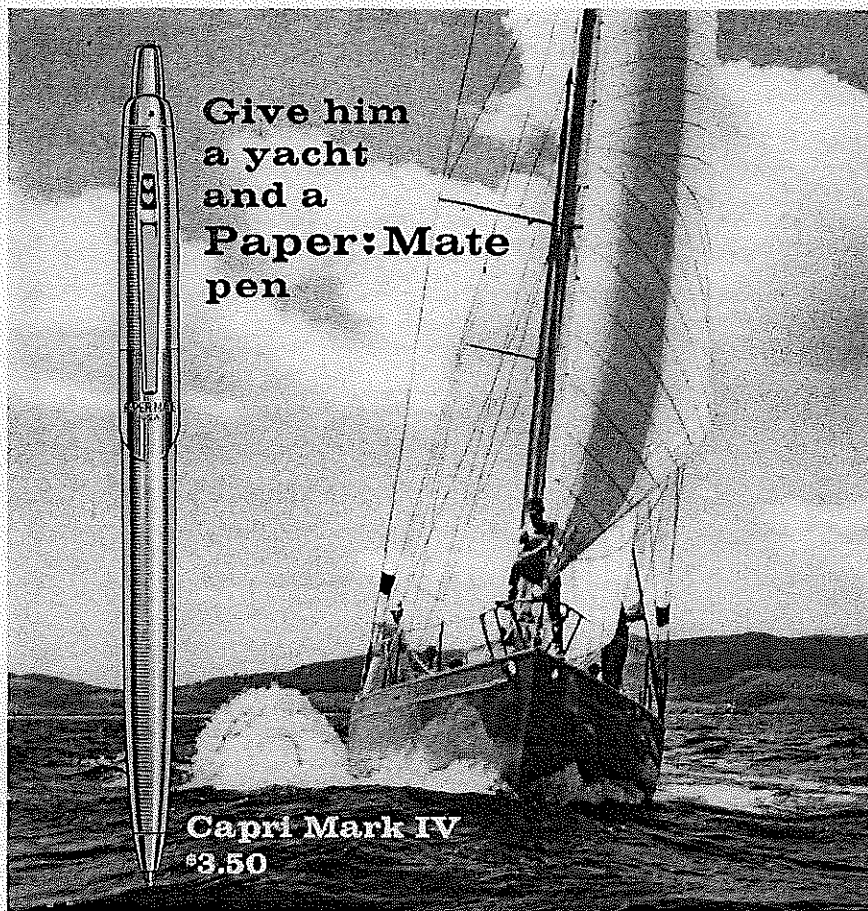
miles. There is no psychological magic and no pain barrier involved. It is merely a process of gradual conditioning.

My method is designed solely for middle-distance and distance runners, not for sprinters, and the results indicate that it is the best method around. My athletes have dominated middle-distance running in New Zealand for years. Twelve of them have represented New Zealand in international competition. Two of them, Murray Halberg and Peter Snell, are Olympic champions. Halberg also holds the world

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ON RECENT VISIT TO U.S., NEW ZEALAND COACH LYDIARD (RIGHT) LEADS PETER SNELL AND MURRAY HALBERG ON DISNEYLAND TOUR

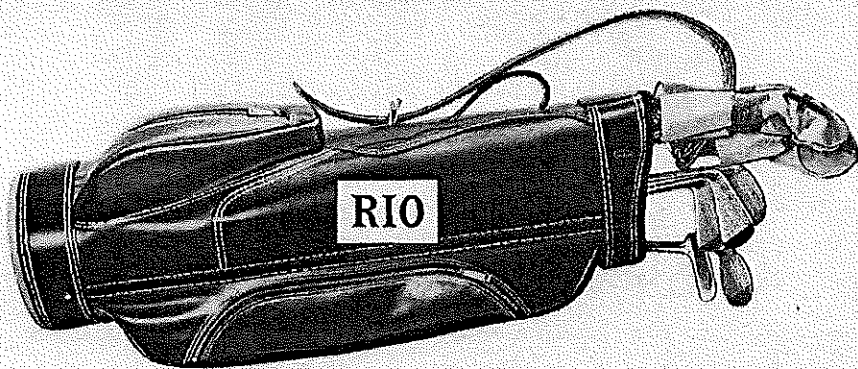




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LYDIARD *continued*

two- and three-mile records and Snell, as you know, broke four world records—mile, half mile, 800 meters and 1,000 yards—in three weeks. That's pretty fair cracking, and Peter will tell you gladly that marathon training is responsible.

Despite the success of marathon training, most of the world's coaches do not use it. They rely solely on repetition or interval training. That is, they make their runners do a fast quarter, then a slow quarter, or a series of sprints, over and over. They do their work on a running track, trying to build up speed. But this type of work does little to build up stamina, which is far more important. We run on the roads, over the hills for 20 or 30 miles. After this, a mile or two-mile race is a lark; it is no problem at all. So what happens? Coming down the stretch, a man like Snell can sprint. He can turn on all his speed. A man like, say, George Kerr, who is much faster, cannot do it. He doesn't have the stamina to use his speed when he needs it most.

The time to shine

There is another problem in repetition training. Athletes trained under it do not know when they will hit their peak. Take England's Gordon Pirie, for example. A top distance runner. But when the big meets—like the European championships or the Olympics—came up he could only hope to be ready for them. The way he trained, he could never be sure. If there is an art to this business, this is it: to be in peak form on the big day. We let the mugs have the unimportant races. We point for the big ones.

Zatopek is a good example of the failure of sole reliance on repetition training. As a national coach, he can tap the whole potential of Czechoslovakia. But where were his men at the Rome Olympics? They didn't win a thing. Yet most coaches still will not believe my system is the right one. One result is that a good many fine prospects have been ruined by excessive speed work and by trying for quick results. That is a shame, but the coaches' stubbornness doesn't bother me. I couldn't care less what they think. I'll let the results speak for themselves.

All my runners, even the half-milers, are basically marathon men. Just before Christmas last year Snell and Halberg entered a regular marathon race. Halberg finished second. Snell took it pretty easy but turned in a good time. Within eight weeks of that race he ran the mile that

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OTHER VIEWS OF THE LYDIARD WAY

At the invitation of Sports Illustrated, star milers, coaches and a director of fitness research comment on the New Zealand coach's unique system of marathon training



HERB ELLIOTT, *Australia, former world mile record holder*: "This supposed extension of endurance implies a barrier which is as mythical as the four-minute mile. If a man has reached the final point of his endurance,

he collapses. That's what the term means. If someone claims to have gone beyond it, he hasn't reached it yet. You've just got to have the potential and to train yourself so you get the very most out of what you've got. Obviously, Snell has done that. But there is no secret. Lydiard can't drive him beyond the limits of endurance because only the man himself really knows his limits. And he's no runner unless he pushes himself to the limits."



PERCY CERUTTI, *Australia, coach of Herb Elliott*: "Lydiard is using the same theory as my own. I call it breaking through the pain barrier. If a man runs beyond himself in the first quarter of a mile race, say, a new release of energy will come later. Afterwards, of course, he will pay a terrible price for it. He will be in a state of complete collapse. But even that isn't dangerous. I do it, I'm 67 and it's never harmed me. Lydiard and I do have differences in our methods. I'm a much less agreeable bloke with my runners. Lydiard kids his along and gets tremendous loyalty from them."



MIHALY IGLOI, *U.S., Hungarian-born coach of Jim Beatty and Jim Grelle*: "Is better to run on the track. I look at Peter Snell run in Los Angeles. I am sure I know how he train and is not all marathon running. Is needed other

kinds of training to make great runner. Some have speed, some stamina, but very few have both. Is needed to know which a runner has to build up. You find out by watching each runner, by taking his times and deciding which is best course of training."



THOMAS CURETON, *U.S., director of the physical fitness research laboratory, University of Illinois*: "All-out work never hurt anybody. I've done it even with middle-aged men. When a man does an all-out exercise he simply rests before doing it again. Many are afraid to go real hard. When a man feels aches and pains he is apt to think he's going all-out. He isn't. Snell has probably trained his tissues to stand high-lactic acid in critical moments. His tolerance of mind makes this possible. He didn't do this quickly. I've never known any serious injuries from all-out training, but the coaches are scared of it."



JIM BEATTY, *U.S., world indoor mile record holder*: "Many times in my own training, I felt I couldn't do more, but the human spirit can always do more. There's no magic formula. You can't say, 'Wow, all of a sudden Snell is great.'"

Look what happened a year and a half ago. He won the Olympics. He was almost in world-record shape then. He's been building ever since. You have to be able to train straight through for two years or more. If you're injured or have to lay off for some reason, you have to go back and start from scratch."



FRANZ STAMPFL, *Australia, Austrian-born coach of Roger Bannister*: "You push the athlete to the point where he thinks he's done enough. If you, the coach, think he can do more then you try to make him do it. But there

is a limit to what you can do with tired, exhausted athletes. What I do is measure and time everything an athlete does. I set a work limit for him, and as soon as he achieves it I move it up a notch. Lydiard's method might take four or five hours daily. My training is more intense, less in volume. In either case, the answer to middle and distance runners is more and more hard work."



DR. ROGER BANNISTER, *England, first four-minute miler*: "Lydiard's methods are not an absolute departure. Let's remember he was fortunate enough to strike upon a most accomplished athlete in Snell. Also, whether he appreciates it or not, Lydiard understands the psychological barriers which must be approached and overcome in a venture of this sort."



JIM ELLIOTT, *U.S., track coach at Villanova*: "A college coach has to take a different approach to conditioning. Scholastic progress comes first, track second. But if I were doing the same type of coaching as Lydiard, I'd

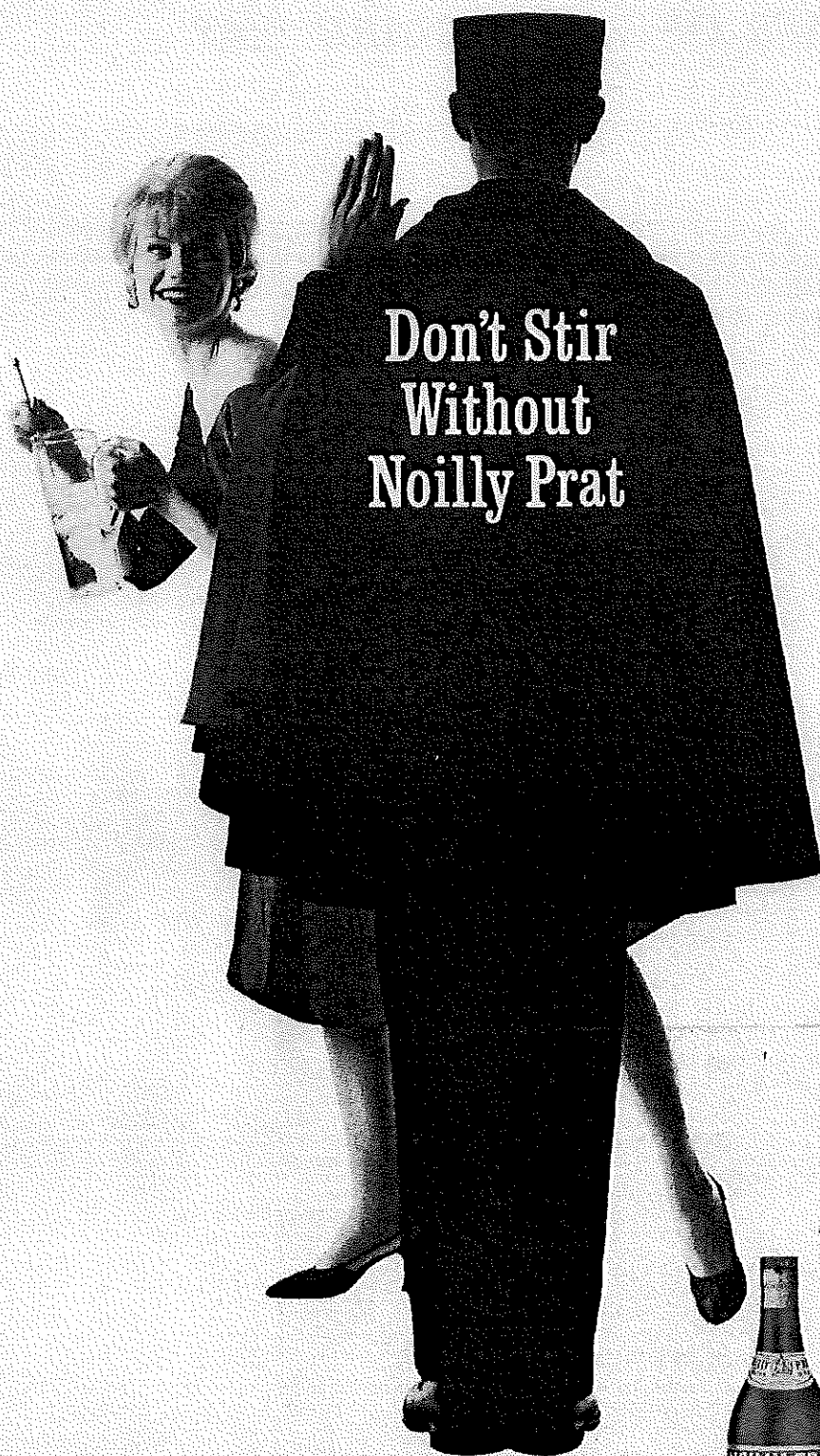
have no quarrel with his methods. If all a boy has to do is concentrate on his running, he can be worked like Snell. Ron Delany would be Snell's match with similar training."



BILL BOWERMAN, *U.S., track coach at the University of Oregon*: "Lydiard is reasonable, and he plans his workouts carefully. He studies his man and arrives at the volume of work he can do according to this knowledge. The man might not think he can do this kind of work, but Lydiard knows better."



TED HAYDON, *U.S., track coach at the University of Chicago*: "Every description I've heard about Snell is that he's strong as a horse. Did he get that way through workouts, or was he that way before he started to run? The state of exhaustion for one man may differ from that for another. When Roger Bannister ran his second record mile at Vancouver, he staggered all over the track. Yet Landy, after running almost as fast, was bouncing around, fresh as a daisy."



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LYDIARD *continued*

broke the world record. That is what marathon training can do for you.

When a chap comes to me and says he wants to run, I tell him to put on his shoes and move out for five or 10 minutes, then turn around and come back. I can tell right away what kind of shape he is in. If he is a novice, I increase his running time gradually, not each day, but as he gets stronger, until he can go an hour out and an hour back. If he is experienced, I start him higher and move him along faster. But the principle is the same—develop physical endurance for the grind that lies ahead. Then we go up into the hills and run on the roads. We spring up one side of the hill and stride out down the other, and the miles roll by. At their peak the boys do 100 miles a week and they run every day of the year. I used to run with them all the time, but I am an administrator now and let boys like Halberg and Snell and Barry Magee act as my subcoaches.

Rain, hail and horse tracks

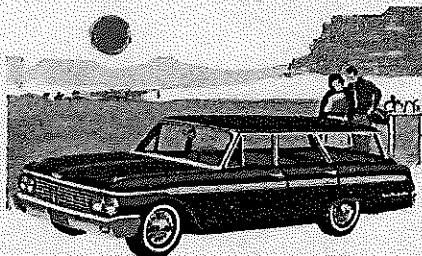
Most of our work is done on roads, but we do a certain amount on all types of firm and soft surfaces. That keeps the legs flexible, and avoids things like shin sores and calf injuries. In our late autumn and winter months, for instance, we run cross country. New Zealand gets a fair bit of rain then so this can be miserable, with hail and rain pounding down on you on a cold winter evening. We also train on horseracing courses. The sliding and slipping on the soft ground strengthens the calf muscles. Then, too, on a dark night a fellow can follow the rail round the course.

Four to six weeks before a big race we move onto a regular running track. By this time the boys have their conditioning. They are lean, fit and loose. Now all they need is some fast work to bring themselves up to racing pitch. They gradually increase the tempo of the training by starting 220s in, say, 30 seconds, then cutting them to 25 seconds. They also alternate between running short and medium distances. This is how we use repetition training, not as the sole means of making a man racing-fit but simply to add the finishing touches to stamina already built by marathon running. About 10 days before the race we begin to taper off, and on the last day take a nice, easy three-mile jog.

To the average coach, spending so little time on the running track is bloody

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LYDIARD *continued*

scandalous. But consider this. Before our European trip last summer the boys had only four weeks of speed work. Yet they lost just two races—both by inches—in six weeks. In Dublin they set a four-mile-relay record with a team that had not worked at baton passing and did not include a single real miler (on the team were half-milers Snell and Gary Philpott, two-and-three-miler Halberg and marathon man Magee).

Weight lifting is very much the thing in track and field these days, but I do not bother with it. I am not against any form of exercise, but for distance runners weight lifting is not an efficient means of training. We do use calisthenics a bit, particularly the high-kicking type favored by ballet dancers, to loosen up and stretch the muscles. There is nothing regular about our use of them, however, and I would bet that Halberg doesn't do any at all.

Fetishes are out

I do not impose a food or sleep regimen of any kind. Sleep is up to the man himself; he is usually so tired he falls into bed without any pushing. He also trains so hard he diets subconsciously. Most of the boys like plenty of eggs and good, fresh meat. We eat a lot of ice cream. We have an occasional glass of ale, too. But never any hard liquor and rarely any pastry stuff. On the day of a race one chap may have eggs, another baked beans, but they both run well.

I don't worry about any of these things because, for distance men, nothing can match steady running. When we are working out on a track we never go to training in an automobile. We always jog over, which often means two or three miles going and two or three miles back. I forget about form, too. If a joker throws his arms around, that's fine, so long as he is fit and relaxed. Then he runs smoother and easier, and form takes care of itself. We want the chap who can run for two or three hours and come back looking as fit as he did when he went out. It is not very difficult, you know.

I do not use much psychology, either. In the initial period, of course, you have to encourage the man to help him over the mental barrier of running 20 miles. The rest is pretty much up to him. I don't want fellows who have to be coaxed along. That is why I never go after a runner. I make him come to me

and ask for help. Then I have got the upper hand.

Coaching champions is only part of my program in New Zealand. For several years I have been going around to men's clubs to talk about the physical benefits of running. Take a typical middle-aged fellow who gets no exercise. If you told him to do some press-ups, he could probably knock out half a dozen and get up without being exhausted. But if you told the same chap to run down the road for half a mile, he couldn't make it back under his own power. After repeated running his breathing and stamina will improve remarkably, and his pulse rate will come down, possibly from a normal 70 or so to around 45 in six months. Maybe only two or three businessmen are willing to try running at first. But pretty soon others are doing it, discovering what a fine way it is to keep healthy and fit. I have the teen-age boys around home running, too. They see my athletes going 20 miles, so they think nothing of going 20 themselves.

Speed is the limit

People want to know what the limit is to all these records. Sometimes I think they would feel more secure if they knew there was a limit. I have already predicted that Peter Snell will be running the mile in 3:48 within two years. If I can get good material, like so many coaches get, there is no telling what I can do. Ideally, I would like to have a good, powerful sprinter, a fellow who has not only great speed but the strength to stand up under marathon training with the proper coaching. Who knows how fast he could run the mile or half mile?

New Zealand has never produced much in the way of sprinters. Anyway, I doubt that I would want a full-time coaching job there. The country is too small to produce enough first-rate material, and the coaches are too jealous of success. But if I could get full security for my family I would take a job anywhere in the world. I would be happy to coach in the States. You haven't done anywhere near as well as you can in middle-distance and distance running. With the great sprinters and general talent you have, I would have no difficulty within two or three years of putting Americans right up top in both those areas. I couldn't miss. You don't realize what you have got. The thing is, it is not facilities that make the champion. It is the will to get on with the job. **END**